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F L E A N E W S

No. 1.

Compiled by the Siphonaptera Section, Department of Entomology,
British Museum (Natural History), South Kensington, London, SW7 5BD.

Dear Colleague,

It may be useful if 'students of fleas' regularly received a list of recently published literature on the subject. At the same time a news sheet could be used by anyone wanting to circulate among colleagues certain Notes or Observations (these should be concise).

With the sanction of the authorities of the British Museum (Natural History) I would like to distribute a Flea News several times a year.

For reasons of economy this news sheet will be kept as concise as possible and will only be sent to those who are seriously interested in the study of fleas. Please inform me if you have no use for Flea News.

Any comments or suggestions will be appreciated, also notifications of omissions in the literature lists.

The opportunity is taken to give some of my own remarks below.

Yours sincerely,

F.G.A.M. Smit.

NOTES AND OBSERVATIONS

Due to a complete reorganisation of Tring Museum (which is now occupied by the entire bird section of the Department of Zoology, BM(NH) and to the stipulation in N.C. Rothschild's Deed of Gift of 1913 (which became effective in 1923) that his collection should be housed in the "Natural History Museum at South Kensington", the combined Rothschild and British Museum collections of Siphonaptera (and documentation) were removed from the Tring Museum in May 1972 and are now in the Department of Entomology, British Museum (Natural History), South Kensington, London SW7 5BD. All communications concerning these collections should be sent to this London address. - Tring no longer means Fleas.

THE IOWA STATE UNIVERSITY
MAY 2 1982

The use of patronymic names for new taxa seems in need of some restraint: no less than 43% of the new names introduced since 1968 are patronyms.

* * *

Another trend which really is undesirable: new taxa described by three authors. Names should be relatively short, but now we have several very long names: genus subgenus species subspecies author author author date.

* * *

Talking about descriptions: it would be most helpful if the coordinates were more often given for localities mentioned; many of us surely have to spend too much time tracing obscure localities. A new fashion (but not widespread): giving the length of whole fleas in hundredths of mm, such as 2.67 mm or 3.49 mm, is of no practical use (because of the telescopic nature of the abdomen, apart from considerable individual variation in size) - 2.7 and 3.5 mm would be accurate enough.

* * *

Slide preparations: these often leave much to be desired. Specimens are often either in too much mounting medium, too squashed (perhaps the worst offence), or not lying on their right-hand side. It is also still not generally realized that Canada balsam is the most suitable of all mounting media (for fleas). If another medium has been used, this should be stated on a slide label (to prevent possible frustration when trying to soak off specimens).

* * *

If a reprint bears an incorrect date, this should be corrected before distribution (e.g. Bull. Soc. Path. exot. 65(6) has 1972 as date but was actually published in June 1973).

* * *

Dr. Polina Andreyevna Petrishcheva died 21.IX.1973 at the age of 73 yrs.

* * *

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(It will be understood that - although their titles are given in English above - papers in Russian or Chinese periodicals are in Russian or Chinese.)